

UNIT III

On the Menu

Imperialism & World War I • 1898–1919



US.19

US.20

US.21

US.22

US.23

US.24

US.25

US.26

US.27

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

In one generation the United States went from healing its own wounds to reaching across the whole world — buying navies, taking islands, and finally sending two million young men to a war in the mud of France. When a country grows into a world power, who pays for the growth? And when it wins, what does it owe the people it now controls?

Twenty years. That's all it took. In 1898 the United States was still a country that mostly looked inward, stitching itself back together after a civil war. By 1919 it had taken islands on the other side of the planet, dug a canal through another country, and sent two million young Americans to die and fight in the trenches of France — coming home as the most powerful nation on earth. This unit is about that breathtaking, dangerous growth spurt. You'll meet Andrés, a Filipino teenager who lives through his homeland being handed from Spain to the United States without anyone asking him. You'll travel with Frankie — the newsboy you already know — now a young war correspondent. You'll march with Ezra, a Tennessee farm boy from the same hills as Sgt. Alvin York, and work beside Lena, a Nashville woman running the home front. Your job isn't to memorize which island we took in which year. It's to weigh a hard question honestly: a country can grow enormously powerful — and some of that growth comes at the direct expense of other people. When is the price worth it? Who gets to decide? And who has to pay?

How this unit works

- Taught through story — you meet a colonized teenager, a soldier, a nurse, and a reporter before you meet a single policy.
- Multiple perspectives — the expansionist and the anti-imperialist, the soldier and the civilian, and crucially the colonized voice, each represented fairly.
- Primary sources — the 1898 cartoons, the Zimmermann Telegram, Wilson's own war message and Fourteen Points, and Sgt. York's diary.
- UDL — a present-day hook, plain-language summaries, cited images, and a choice of ways to respond on every spread.
- Nation power vs. cost to a people — this unit surfaces the causation question directly: does the country grow at someone's expense?
- The Arc of the Union — plot 1898–1919's climbs, setbacks, and mixed cases on the trajectory you're building all year.

Flight crew this unit:

Archive (J. Troop)

Spark

Navigator

Notetaker

Who you'll travel with in this unit



Andrés, 15
Manila, the Philippines



Frankie, 23
New York → the
Western Front, France



Ezra, 24
The Cumberland
Plateau, Fentress
County, Tennessee



Lena, 19
Nashville, Tennessee

Spread 1 • US.19, US.20

Analyze the economic, strategic, and ideological motives behind American imperialism, and the debate between imperialists and anti-imperialists.

 Picture a menu — but the items aren't food. They're countries. Cuba, Puerto Rico, the Philippines, Hawaii, all laid out like dishes, and a giant customer leaning back deciding which one to order first. That was an actual 1898 cartoon, and it wasn't even exaggerating. In one lifetime the United States went from a country recovering from civil war to a country shopping for an empire. The only question left was whether that was the American dream — or a betrayal of it.

The C-130 drops out of the clouds over a harbor bristling with new steel warships. Archive taps the glass. 'Every empire tells itself a story about why it deserves what it takes,' she says. 'Today you're going to hear three of those stories — and one voice from the people being served up on the menu.'

INSTITUTION

The expansionists • why a country reaches

The men pushing America outward had three reasons, and they said them out loud. First, money: American factories and farms were producing more than Americans could buy, and they wanted foreign markets and raw materials. Second, strength: a naval officer named Alfred Thayer Mahan argued that real world powers needed a great navy — and great navies needed coaling stations and bases across the oceans. Third, mission: many Americans genuinely believed it was their duty to spread their civilization, religion, and way of life to peoples they saw as 'backward.' Markets, navies, and mission — that's the engine of American imperialism, and it's important to understand it before you judge it.

GROUP

The Anti-Imperialist League • the country arguing with itself

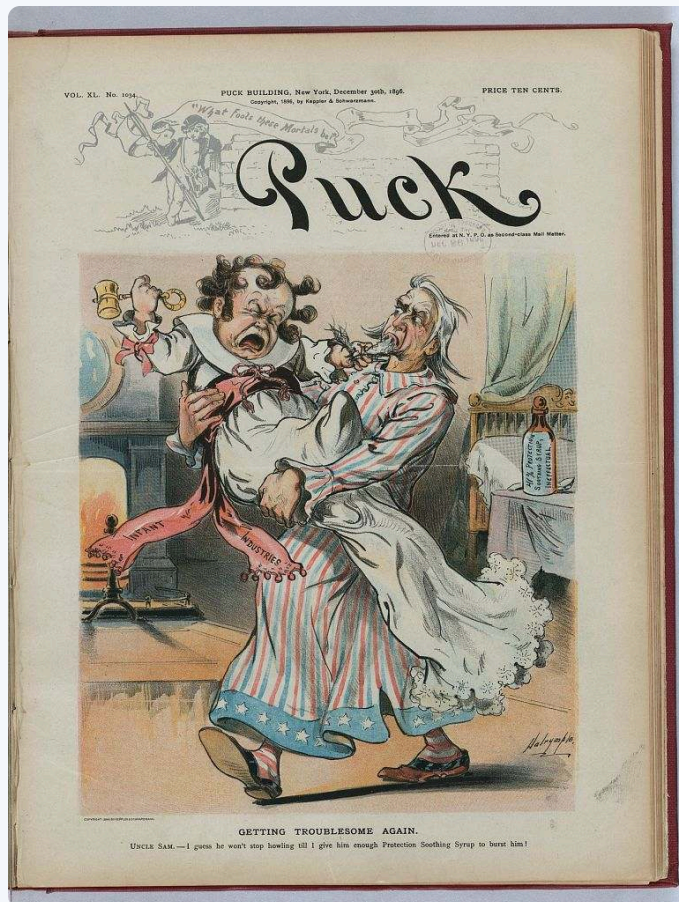
Not everyone cheered. In 1899 a remarkable group — including the writer Mark Twain and three-time presidential candidate William Jennings Bryan — formed the American Anti-Imperialist League, and their argument cut to the bone: a country founded on the idea that governments derive their power from 'the consent of the governed' cannot then rule millions of people who never gave consent. To them, taking colonies didn't make America stronger — it made America a hypocrite. This is the heart of US.20: the fight wasn't Americans versus foreigners. It was Americans versus Americans, arguing over what their own founding words actually meant.



ERA-FRIEND

Andrés • the one on the menu

Andrés is fifteen, and he lives in Manila. He has one perspective nobody in Washington has: he is the item on the plate. His homeland, the Philippines, spent centuries as a Spanish colony. Then in 1898 Filipinos rose up believing independence was finally within reach — only to watch their islands handed to the United States as a prize of war, for twenty million dollars, without a single Filipino at the table. Andrés hears the American speeches about liberty and mission, and he asks the simplest, sharpest question in this entire unit: liberty for whom? A country can call itself free and still take your freedom. He's about to prove it.



📷 This 1898 political cartoon depicts Uncle Sam as a customer eyeing a menu of Spanish colonies like Cuba and the Philippines served by President McKinley, critiquing U.S. imperial ambitions during the Spanish-American War as covered in Tennessee US.26.

Well, I hardly know which to take first! 1898. Wood engraving. PRES FILE - McKinley, William, 1843-1901--Cartoons & item; [P&P]. Library of Congress Prints and Photographs Division, <https://www.loc.gov/pictures/item/96512090/>.

💡 This is the 'menu' cartoon itself — Uncle Sam deciding which country to 'order,' served by President McKinley. Ask: the cartoonist drew whole nations as dinner items. What is that image saying about power — and would the people of Cuba or the Philippines have drawn it the same way?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



This 1899 Puck magazine cartoon depicts Uncle Sam as a teacher 'civilizing' new territories like Cuba and the Philippines while marginalized groups are



This map illustrates U.S. territorial acquisitions through 1900, highlighting expansions from the Spanish-American War

sidelined, a lens on imperialism and self-determination (TN US.20, US.27).

that marked America's emergence as an imperial power (TN US.19, US.21).

In plain words: In the late 1800s the United States began taking lands overseas — this is called imperialism. There were three main reasons: money (new markets and materials), military strength (a big navy needed bases), and a belief that America should spread its way of life. But many Americans disagreed. The Anti-Imperialist League, including Mark Twain, said a country built on 'consent of the governed' had no right to rule people who never agreed to it. Andrés, a teen in the Philippines, lived this from the other side: his country was taken without anyone asking him.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee was part of the story from the start. By 1898 Southern states — Tennessee among them — rallied behind the war with Spain, and former Confederate officers put on U.S. uniforms again. For a South still sore from the Civil War, waving the same flag in a foreign war became a way to feel like one country again. Expansion abroad, in other words, was partly about healing a wound at home.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** The United States began ruling overseas peoples who had no vote and no consent in the government now over them.
- **Head out of the sand:** Anti-imperialists like Mark Twain and William Jennings Bryan — and the colonized peoples themselves, like Andrés.
- **Voice raised:** Public debate, the press, and the organized Anti-Imperialist League.
- **Government response:** The expansionists largely won the immediate argument; the U.S. kept its new territories, and full self-government for places like the Philippines came only decades later.
- **Still unfinished:** The tension between American ideals and American power over other peoples runs through the whole century that follows.

✓ **Check:** Name the three main motives for American imperialism, then explain the core argument the Anti-Imperialist League used against it. Whose reasoning do you find stronger, and why?

Show what you know:

- Write the letter Andrés might send to Mark Twain after reading about the Anti-Imperialist League.
 - Redraw the 'menu' cartoon from the point of view of the people on the plate.
 - Debate: were the three motives for imperialism enough to justify ruling people without their consent? Use evidence.
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Spread 2 · US.21, US.22

Analyze the causes, course, and consequences of the Spanish-American War, and how Roosevelt's Big Stick and Taft's Dollar Diplomacy extended U.S. power afterward.

🔊 A ship blows up in a harbor. Nobody knows exactly why. But two newspapers, locked in a war for readers, splash it across their front pages: 'REMEMBER THE MAINE!' — Spain did it, they scream, with no proof. Within weeks the country is howling for war. If you've ever watched a rumor go viral and turn into 'fact' before anyone checks it, you already understand 1898. The difference is that this time, the viral rumor started a war — and built an empire.

Archive sets the crew down on a Cuban hillside as gunfire crackles below. 'Watch how fast this goes,' she says. 'A ninety-day war. And when the smoke clears, a country that owned no colonies suddenly owns a string of them across two oceans — and has to decide what kind of power it wants to be.'

INSTITUTION

The press and the war · ninety days that made an empire

The Spanish-American War came from a stew of causes: real American sympathy for Cubans fighting Spanish rule, American business interests in the island, and 'yellow journalism' — sensational newspapers that exaggerated Spanish cruelty to sell papers and stoke outrage. When the U.S. battleship Maine exploded in Havana harbor in 1898, the papers blamed Spain without proof, and the country went to war. It lasted about ninety days. When it ended, the United States had taken Puerto Rico, Guam, and the Philippines, and had made Cuba a protectorate. A country with no overseas empire had, in one summer, become an imperial power.



ERA-FRIEND

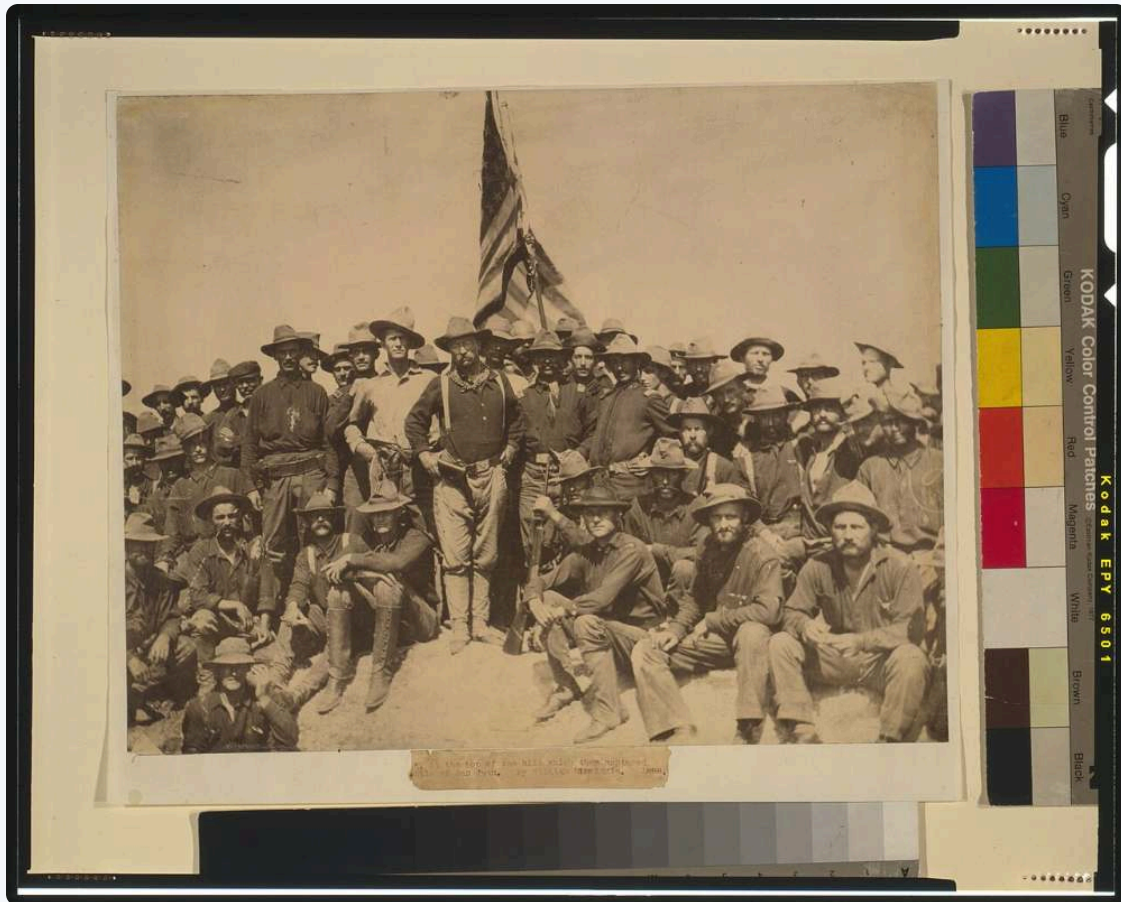
Andrés · the war that didn't end for him

For most Americans the war ended in 1898 with a parade. For Andrés it was just beginning. Filipinos had fought Spain expecting independence — and instead found the United States taking Spain's place as ruler. So they fought again, this time against the Americans, in a brutal war from 1899 to 1902 that killed thousands of Filipino soldiers and far more civilians. The same country that had gone to war 'to free Cuba from Spain' was now crushing a Filipino independence movement. Andrés wants you to see the pattern the parades hid: a war sold as liberation became, for his people, a new occupation.

INSTITUTION

Big Stick and Dollar Diplomacy · what to do with new power

Now the United States had power abroad — and two presidents showed two ways to use it. Theodore Roosevelt's 'Big Stick' diplomacy meant negotiating softly while holding a very real threat of force: he backed a revolution to build the Panama Canal, and his Roosevelt Corollary claimed the right to police the whole Western Hemisphere. His successor, William Howard Taft, preferred 'Dollar Diplomacy' — extending American influence through money and investment rather than troops. Different tools, same goal: keep American power growing. Both raised the same question Andrés keeps asking — powerful for us, but at what cost to them?

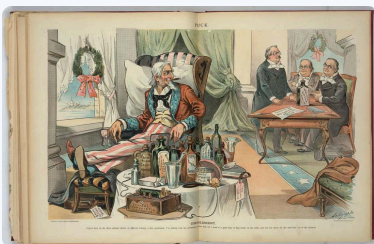


📷 Colonel Theodore Roosevelt stands with his Rough Riders atop the captured hill during the Battle of San Juan Hill in 1898, a pivotal moment in the Spanish-American War that showcased American military prowess and expansionism as covered in Tennessee US.26.

Dinwiddie, William. [Colonel Roosevelt and his Rough Riders at the top of the hill which they captured, Battle of San Juan]. Photograph. 1898. LOT 11519, no. 15 [P&P]. Library of Congress, Prints and Photographs Division, Washington, D.C. <https://www.loc.gov/pictures/item/96521936/>.

💡 This is Theodore Roosevelt with his Rough Riders atop the hill they captured at San Juan, 1898 — the image that made Roosevelt a national hero and helped carry him to the presidency. Ask: this photograph shows the winners at the top of the hill. Who is not in the frame — and how does that shape the story Americans told about the war?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



This 1898 political cartoon depicts Cuba trapped between Spanish misrule and anarchy, urging U.S. intervention during

In plain words: In 1898 the U.S. went to war with Spain. Causes included sympathy for Cuba, business interests, exaggerated 'yellow journalism,' and the explosion of the USS Maine. The war lasted only about 90 days, but afterward the U.S. controlled Puerto Rico, Guam, the Philippines, and Cuba. For Filipinos like Andrés, it meant a new war (1899–1902) against American rule. Two presidents then used the new power differently: Roosevelt's 'Big Stick' (force and the Panama Canal) and Taft's 'Dollar Diplomacy' (money and investment).

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee suited up. The state raised volunteer regiments for the 1898 war, part of that wave of Southern enthusiasm that helped knit the country back together a generation after the Civil War. Tennessee boys who had grown up on stories of Shiloh now marched under the United States flag toward Cuba — proof that the fever for this war reached all the way into Tennessee's own towns and farms.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** After 1898 the U.S. held territories and a sphere of influence full of people with no say in the American government now shaping their lives.
- **Head out of the sand:** Filipino independence fighters, anti-imperialists at home, and later critics of intervention in Latin America.
- **Voice raised:** Armed resistance (the Philippine-American War), political debate, and the press.
- **Government response:** The U.S. suppressed Filipino resistance and expanded its reach through the Big Stick and Dollar Diplomacy; self-rule came only much later.
- **Still unfinished:** How the U.S. uses its power in Latin America and the Pacific stays contested for the rest of the century.

✓ **Check:** Explain how the Spanish-American War turned the U.S. into an imperial power, then compare Big Stick and Dollar Diplomacy as two ways of using that new power. Include the war's consequences for Filipinos.

Show what you know:

- Write two front-page headlines about the Maine — one from 1898 yellow journalism, one written responsibly with what we now know.
 - Make a two-column chart comparing Big Stick and Dollar Diplomacy: tool, example, and cost.
 - Debate: was the Spanish-American War a war of liberation, a war of empire, or both? Cite evidence.
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Spread 3 • US.23, US.24

Analyze the long-term causes of World War I (MAIN) and the reasons the United States abandoned neutrality and entered the war.

🔊 Europe in 1914 was a room full of people soaked in gasoline, and everyone was holding a match and swearing they'd only light it if someone else did first. It took one assassination — one — to set the whole room on fire. America stood in the doorway for three years saying 'not our fight.' Then a secret telegram and a string of sunk ships pulled the most powerful young country on earth straight into the flames.

Archive climbs the C-130 high over a Europe crisscrossed with trenches. 'Historians have a four-letter word for why this happened,' she says. 'M-A-I-N. Learn it and you can explain the deadliest war the world had ever seen — and then we'll figure out why America, three thousand miles away, decided it couldn't stay out.'

INSTITUTION

MAIN • why the whole world caught fire

World War I didn't start over one thing — it started over four, and they spell MAIN. Militarism: Europe's powers had spent decades building enormous armies and navies and glorifying war. Alliances: they'd tangled themselves into two rival teams — the Triple Alliance and the Triple Entente — so a fight between two countries could drag in six. Imperialism: they competed fiercely for colonies and resources. Nationalism: intense pride and ethnic tension made every nation itch to prove itself. All that was the gasoline. The match was the 1914 assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand. Within weeks, the alliances did exactly what alliances do, and the world was at war.



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie • the reporter watching neutrality crack

Frankie is twenty-three now, a war correspondent, and at first he reports what most Americans believe: this is Europe's mess, not ours. President Wilson had even won reelection partly on 'He kept us out of war.' But Frankie watches the wall between America and the war crack, piece by piece. German submarines are sinking ships without warning, including the Lusitania in 1915, killing American passengers. Then, in early 1917, comes the Zimmermann Telegram — a secret German message proposing that Mexico attack the United States. Frankie can feel the mood turn. Neutrality, he writes in his notebook, is a door — and Germany keeps kicking it open.

PRIMARY VOICE

Woodrow Wilson · 'safe for democracy'

By April 1917 President Wilson had run out of doorway to stand in. He went before Congress and asked for a declaration of war, and he framed it not as revenge for sunk ships but as a mission: 'The world must be made safe for democracy.' It was a soaring, idealistic reason for a grim decision — America would fight, Wilson said, not to conquer but to build a better, more peaceful world order. Hold onto that promise, because this unit is going to test it. A war entered for the highest ideals still has to be fought in the lowest places: the mud, the wire, and the trenches Ezra is about to enter.



Primary source: The Zimmermann Telegram (January 1917): a secret message in which Germany's foreign minister proposed that, if the U.S. entered the war, Mexico ally with Germany and reclaim Texas, New Mexico, and Arizona. British intelligence intercepted it and shared it with Washington.



A single intercepted telegram helped move a nation of 100 million toward war. Why would a secret document aimed at Mexico do more to change American minds than years of events in Europe?

In plain words: World War I started in Europe in 1914. The long-term causes spell MAIN: Militarism (huge armies), Alliances (rival teams of nations), Imperialism (fighting over colonies), and Nationalism (intense national pride). The spark was the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand. The U.S. tried to stay neutral for three years. But German submarines sank ships (including the Lusitania, 1915), and the Zimmermann Telegram (1917) revealed Germany asking Mexico to attack the U.S. In April 1917 Wilson asked Congress for war to make 'the world safe for democracy.'



Tennessee: When the call came, Tennessee answered in force. About 100,000 Tennesseans served in World War I, many in the 30th 'Old Hickory' Division — named for Tennessee's own Andrew Jackson — which would go on to help smash through Germany's Hindenburg Line. And Tennessee Congressman Cordell Hull was in Washington through the whole debate over entering the war, beginning a career that would make him one of America's great voices for engaging with the world.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** A European war threatened American lives and shipping while the country was divided over whether to get involved.
- **Head out of the sand:** Journalists, the public reacting to submarine attacks, and a president weighing neutrality against provocation.
- **Voice raised:** Public debate, the press, and ultimately a presidential war message and a congressional vote.
- **Government response:** Congress declared war in April 1917, and the U.S. mobilized millions of men and its whole economy.
- **Still unfinished:** When America should enter a foreign war — and on what justification — becomes a defining question for the next hundred years.

✓ **Check:** Explain the MAIN causes of World War I, then explain how the U.S. moved from neutrality to war. Identify the two events that most turned American opinion.

Show what you know:

- Draw the 'gasoline and a match' as a labeled diagram of the four MAIN causes plus the spark.
 - Write Frankie's notebook entry the day the Zimmermann Telegram becomes public.
 - Debate: was the U.S. right to abandon neutrality in 1917? Argue it using the Lusitania, the Zimmermann Telegram, and the complications.
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Spread 4 • US.25

Analyze the American military experience in World War I — trench warfare, deadly new technologies, and Pershing's American Expeditionary Forces — through a Tennessee lens.

🔊 Imagine a war where you live in a muddy ditch for months, where poison gas can roll in on the wind, where a machine gun can cut down a hundred men in a minute, and where 'going over the top' means climbing out of the only thing protecting you and running straight at all of it. That was the Western Front. And into that nightmare walked a farm boy from the Tennessee mountains who didn't even want to fight — and became the most famous soldier in America.

Archive lands the crew behind the American lines in France, 1918. The horizon flickers with artillery. 'Wilson said we entered this war for ideals,' she says quietly. 'Here's where the ideals meet the mud. Watch a Tennessee boy carry his whole conscience into it.'



ERA-FRIEND

Ezra • a plowman in the trenches

Ezra grew up on the Cumberland Plateau, hands hardened by a plow, raised in a church that told him killing was a sin. Now he's in a French trench, and the war he's found is like nothing in human history. He learns the new machinery of death fast: machine guns that make a charge across open ground almost suicide, poison gas that burns the lungs, tanks and airplanes and endless artillery. He serves under General John J. Pershing, commander of the American Expeditionary Forces, the two million Americans sent to tip the balance. Ezra is terrified and homesick and doing his duty — and he's carrying the same crisis of conscience that made another Tennessee mountain boy a legend.

PRIMARY VOICE

Sgt. Alvin C. York · the conscience and the medal

Alvin York was real, and he was from Pall Mall, in Fentress County, Tennessee — the same hard hills as Ezra. York was a devout man who at first sought to be a conscientious objector; he did not believe in killing. His officers and his own long wrestling with scripture eventually convinced him this war was just. Then on October 8, 1918, in the Argonne Forest, York's unit was pinned by machine-gun fire, and he did something almost impossible: he helped capture 132 German soldiers and silenced the guns. He received the Medal of Honor and came home one of the most decorated and famous soldiers of the war. His diary lets you watch a man carry his faith straight through the worst day of his life.

INSTITUTION

The AEF · what two million Americans meant

By the time large numbers of fresh American troops reached France in 1918, the European armies had been bleeding each other for nearly four years and were exhausted. The American Expeditionary Forces brought manpower, supplies, and momentum that helped the Allies push Germany back in the war's final campaigns. It came at a terrible price — more than 50,000 Americans died in combat and many more from disease. But the arrival of the AEF is a major reason the war ended in late 1918, and a major reason the United States walked out of it as a first-rank world power.



Primary source: The war diary of Sgt. Alvin C. York records his transformation from a Tennessee farmer and would-be conscientious objector into a soldier — and his account of the October 8, 1918 action in the Argonne for which he received the Medal of Honor.



York wrote as a deeply religious man who did not want to kill, then found himself in the middle of the war's violence. What does it change about a battle to read it in the words of someone who wrestled with whether he should be fighting at all?

In plain words: World War I on the Western Front meant trench warfare — soldiers living in muddy ditches — and terrible new weapons: machine guns, poison gas, tanks, and airplanes. General John J. Pershing led the two million American troops (the AEF), whose arrival in 1918 helped the tired Allies win. A Tennessee mountain farmer named Sgt. Alvin C. York, who first wanted to be a conscientious objector because of his faith, became a hero on October 8, 1918, helping capture 132 German soldiers and earning the Medal of Honor.

● **Tennessee:** This spread's Tennessee connection is one of the most famous stories in the entire war. Sgt. Alvin C. York came from Pall Mall in Fentress County, on the Cumberland Plateau — a poor, rural, deeply religious corner of East Tennessee. A man who wrestled hard with whether a Christian could kill became, by the war's end, one of America's most decorated soldiers. Tennessee didn't just send troops to WWI; it produced its single most legendary hero.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** The United States had to raise, arm, and send an army into the most lethal form of warfare yet seen.
- **Head out of the sand:** Soldiers like Ezra and York, and commanders like Pershing, who had to make an untested army effective fast.
- **Voice raised:** Military service itself, and later the letters, diaries, and testimony of the men who fought.
- **Government response:** The U.S. drafted and mobilized millions and committed the AEF to the decisive 1918 campaigns.
- **Still unfinished:** How a nation asks young people to kill and die — and how it honors both their courage and their conscience — is never fully settled.

✓ **Check:** Describe what made World War I combat so deadly, and explain the role of the American Expeditionary Forces. Then explain why Alvin York's story is more complicated than 'brave soldier.'

Show what you know:

- Write a diary entry in Ezra's voice the night before going 'over the top,' grounded in the real conditions.
 - Create an annotated diagram of the Western Front: trench, no-man's-land, and three new technologies.
 - Record a respectful two-minute profile of Alvin York that centers his conscience, not just his medal.
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Spread 5 • US.26

Analyze the World War I home front — women's expanded roles, mobilization and war bonds, and the Committee on Public Information's propaganda.

🔊 Here's something they don't always tell you about war: most of the people fighting it never see the front. They're at home, and their whole world gets rewired overnight — new jobs, rationed food, and a government that suddenly has a very strong opinion about what you should think and say. In WWI the United States built the first modern propaganda machine and pointed it at its own citizens. And the person who kept the whole home front running? Very often, she was a woman.

Archive brings the crew down not in France, but in Nashville — outside an enormous new factory going up almost overnight. 'The war is here too,' she says. 'In this plant, in these kitchens, in the posters on every wall. Watch a country mobilize a whole society — and watch it learn to manage what people believe.'



ERA-FRIEND

Lena • the home front is a front

Lena is nineteen, and before the war her future looked small and settled. The war blows it open. With millions of men in uniform, women step into jobs that were closed to them the year before — factory work, clerical work, running farms and businesses. Lena trains as a nurse and takes shifts at the giant powder plant rising at Old Hickory outside Nashville. She rations food, buys war bonds, and discovers something that will outlast the war: she is capable of far more than anyone told her. The home front isn't the war's sideline. For millions of American women, it's where the twentieth century actually begins.

INSTITUTION

The Committee on Public Information • manufacturing consent

To unite a divided country behind the war, the government created the Committee on Public Information (CPI), led by George Creel — the first large-scale government propaganda operation in American history. It flooded the country with posters, pamphlets, films, and tens of thousands of 'Four-Minute Men' who gave short pro-war speeches in theaters. Some of it was simple patriotism; some of it demonized Germans and pressured anyone who questioned the war into silence. The CPI is one of the most important and uncomfortable stories in this unit: it shows how a free society, at war, learned to shape — and sometimes police — what its own people thought.



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie • a reporter watching the truth get managed

Frankie, the correspondent, sees the CPI from the inside of his own profession, and it unsettles him. He has spent his life believing that a true story, printed, sets people free — the muckraker's faith. Now he watches the same tools he loves used to manage a whole nation's beliefs, to sell bonds and silence doubt. He isn't naïve; he understands why a country at war wants unity. But he writes a hard note to himself: the same press that exposed Standard Oil can also be aimed at the public instead of at the powerful. A free press is a weapon — and Frankie realizes weapons can be turned around.

 **Primary source:** On the WWI home front, women took new roles in factories and nursing, the Committee on Public Information spread pro-war propaganda, and civilians rationed food and bought war bonds to fund the war effort.

 The government asked citizens to give money, change how they ate, and support the war — and used posters and speeches to persuade them. Where is the line between rallying a country and manipulating it? Does war move that line?

In plain words: During WWI, the home front changed American life. With men away fighting, women took new jobs in factories, offices, farms, and nursing. Civilians rationed food and bought war bonds to pay for the war. The government created the Committee on Public Information (CPI) — the first big U.S. propaganda agency — which used posters, films, and speakers to build support for the war and sometimes to silence critics. It raised a hard question: where's the line between rallying a country and controlling what people think?

 **Tennessee:** You can see the whole home front in one Tennessee place: Old Hickory. In 1918 the DuPont company built a massive smokeless-powder plant at Old Hickory, just outside Nashville — a war-production boomtown that employed tens of thousands of workers, including many women like Lena. Nashville's economy and workforce were transformed almost overnight. The war didn't just take Tennessee's sons overseas; it rebuilt Tennessee's factories and workforce at home.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Fighting a total war required mobilizing the entire society and unifying a divided public behind it.
- **Head out of the sand:** Women who filled essential jobs, workers who built war material, and a government determined to unify opinion.
- **Voice raised:** War work, war-bond drives, and a vast government information and propaganda campaign.
- **Government response:** The government organized the economy, funded the war through bonds, and ran the CPI to shape public support.
- **Still unfinished:** The women's expanded roles helped fuel the final push for suffrage, while the propaganda machine left lasting questions about free speech in wartime.

✓ **Check:** Describe two major ways World War I changed the American home front, then explain what the Committee on Public Information was and one reason it is controversial.

Show what you know:

- Design a WWI home-front poster — then write a short note on where your poster informs and where it manipulates.
 - Write Lena's letter to a friend describing her first month at the Old Hickory plant.
 - Debate: is government propaganda ever justified in wartime? Use the CPI as your evidence.
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Spread 6 • US.27

Analyze Wilson's Fourteen Points, the Treaty of Versailles, and the debate over the League of Nations — including Tennessee's internationalist voice.

 The war is over. Ten million soldiers are dead. And an American president stands up and says: what if we made sure this never happens again? What if nations settled disputes by talking instead of killing? It was one of the boldest ideas in modern history — a permanent league to keep the peace. And then the country that dreamed it up... refused to join. This is the story of the most important 'almost' in American history.

Last stop. Archive sets the crew down in Paris, 1919, where the winners are carving up the world, then jumps them to the U.S. Senate floor. 'Watch a country reach for something huge,' she says, 'and then watch it pull its hand back. Both of those are America too.'

PRIMARY VOICE

Woodrow Wilson • the Fourteen Points

Even before the war ended, Wilson had laid out his vision in the Fourteen Points (January 1918) — a blueprint for a peace that would actually last. It called for open diplomacy instead of secret deals, freedom of the seas, reduced armaments, and, most famously, self-determination: the idea that peoples should choose their own governments. The capstone was the fourteenth point — a League of Nations, a permanent assembly where countries would resolve conflicts by talking instead of fighting. It was idealistic to the point of dreaming. Wilson believed the war's ocean of blood could purchase a genuinely new kind of world. He would spend the rest of his health trying to make it real.

INSTITUTION

Versailles and the Senate • the dream meets the world

Reality was harder than the dream. At Paris, the victorious Allies wrote the Treaty of Versailles (1919), which forced Germany to accept blame, pay crushing reparations, and give up territory — terms so harsh that many historians link them to the resentment that fed the next world war. The treaty did create Wilson's League of Nations. But back home, the U.S. Senate — led by Henry Cabot Lodge — refused to ratify it, fearing the League could drag America into future wars without Congress's consent. In a stunning twist, the nation whose president invented the League never joined it. Wilson's grand design launched without its architect aboard.

GROUP

Tennessee's internationalists · the argument that didn't die

The Senate's 'no' didn't settle the question — it only paused it. And one of the strongest voices insisting that America must engage with the world came from Tennessee. Cordell Hull, a congressman and later senator from the Tennessee hill country, championed internationalism through these years. A generation later, as Secretary of State, he would help design the United Nations — the second attempt at exactly what the League tried to be — and win the Nobel Peace Prize for it. Wilson's idea lost the vote in 1919. But a Tennessean helped make sure it eventually won the century.



📷 This 1899 Puck magazine cartoon depicts Uncle Sam as a teacher civilizing new territories like Cuba and the Philippines, while established states study and marginalized groups like Native Americans and Chinese are sidelined, critiquing U.S. imperialism following the Spanish-American War as covered in TN US.27.

Dalrymple, Louis. "School begins." Political cartoon. Chromolithograph. Published by Keppler & Schwarzmann in Puck, v. 44, no. 1142 (1899 January 25), centerfold. Library of Congress, Prints and Photographs Division, Illus. in AP101.P7 1899 (Case X) [P&P], <https://www.loc.gov/pictures/item/2012647459/>.

💡 This 1899 cartoon shows Uncle Sam as a stern schoolteacher 'instructing' Cuba, Puerto Rico, Hawaii, and the Philippines in self-government — while marginalized groups sit at the edges. Ask: twenty years later, Wilson championed 'self-determination' abroad. How do you square that word with this picture of who America thought was ready to govern themselves?

In plain words: After WWI, President Wilson proposed the Fourteen Points (1918) — a plan for lasting peace based on open diplomacy, self-determination (peoples choosing their own governments), and a League of Nations to settle disputes peacefully. The Treaty of Versailles (1919) punished Germany harshly and created the League. But the U.S. Senate, led by Henry Cabot Lodge, refused to join, fearing it would pull America into future wars. The country that invented the League never joined it. Tennessee's Cordell Hull kept the internationalist idea alive and later helped found the United Nations.

● **Tennessee:** When the country turned inward after WWI, one of the loudest voices for staying engaged with the world belonged to a Tennessean. Cordell Hull — from the hills of Overton and Pickett counties — spent these years championing internationalism, and decades later, as Franklin Roosevelt's Secretary of State, he became known as the 'Father of the United Nations' and won the Nobel Peace Prize. The League failed in 1919, but the Tennessee-shaped idea behind it came back and reshaped the world.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** World War I killed millions and left the world searching for a way to prevent the next catastrophe.
- **Head out of the sand:** Wilson and internationalists who proposed a permanent system for resolving disputes without war.
- **Voice raised:** The Fourteen Points, the Paris peace negotiations, and the U.S. Senate ratification debate.
- **Government response:** The Allies created the League of Nations in the Treaty of Versailles, but the U.S. Senate refused to join it.
- **Still unfinished:** The dream of collective security returned after the next world war as the United Nations — with a Tennessean, Cordell Hull, helping build it.

✓ **Check:** Explain Wilson's Fourteen Points and the League of Nations, then explain why the U.S. Senate rejected the Treaty of Versailles. Was the Senate's decision wise or a mistake? Defend your answer.

Show what you know:

- Rank Wilson's Fourteen Points from most to least achievable, and defend your top and bottom choice.
 - Write the speech a Tennessee senator might give either for or against joining the League in 1919.
 - Debate: should the U.S. have joined the League of Nations? Use the treaty, the Senate's fears, and Hull's later work as evidence.
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Toward a more perfect union

Units 1 and 2 asked what the country owed the people inside it. Unit 3 asks a bigger, harder version: what does a rising world power owe the people outside it — and the young men it sends to fight? Watch this unit hold two true things at once. The United States really did become a global power that could tip the balance of a world war and imagine a new kind of peace. And that same rise put millions of people — Filipinos, Cubans, Puerto Ricans, and the soldiers in the trenches — under a power they never chose. Growth and cost, on the same page.

Closing question: This unit put a hard idea on the table: a nation can grow more powerful at the same moment it does real harm to a people. Choose one event from this unit and argue two things at once — how it strengthened the United States, AND what it cost, and to whom. Then take a stand: was the trade worth it? Cite the unit. There's no answer key — make the case honestly.

This unit on the Arc of the Union

You decide: did each of these move the country **toward** its founding promise of liberty and equality for all — or away from it? There's no answer key — mark your own read and defend it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	What happened	Your call
1898	Spanish-American War: the U.S. becomes an empire	A ninety-day war leaves the U.S. holding Puerto Rico, Guam, the Philippines, and oversight of Cuba.	
1899	Philippine-American War	The U.S. suppresses a Filipino independence movement in a brutal war (1899–1902).	
1904	Panama Canal & the Roosevelt Corollary (Big Stick)	Roosevelt backs Panama's split from Colombia to build the canal and claims a hemispheric policing role.	

Year	Milestone	What happened	Your call
1917	The United States enters World War I	Two million Americans go to France; the U.S. emerges from the war a leading world power.	
1918	The Fourteen Points: a new vision of peace	Wilson proposes self-determination and a League of Nations to prevent future wars.	
1919	The Senate rejects the Treaty and the League	The nation whose president designed the League refuses to join it.	